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POLITICS - Valley activist Daniel Brin makes long-shot run for state Assembly

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Daniel Brin, a progressive activist and president of the West Hills Neighborhood Council, has entered the special election in California Assembly District 45, saying he's the candidate who knows west San Fernando Valley communities the best.

The 64-year-old Democrat concedes that his first bid for public office will be a long-shot effort as he competes with at least six opponents, including former Los Angeles City Councilman Dennis Zine, who is running as an independent; Jesse Gabriel, Tricia Robbins Kasson, Ankur Patel and Raymond Bishop, all Democrats; and Justin Clark, a Republican.

Brin hopes voters' familiarity with his work on West Valley issues and on social media such as West Hills' popular Facebook page will help his low-budget campaign for the April 3 special-election primary to replace Matt Dababneh, a Democrat who quit the Assembly after women accused him of sexual misconduct.

"I'm the only one coming from the neighborhood council system, the only one who really has a profound, deep understanding of the issues of importance to regular people here," Brin said in a phone interview.

His work with the West Hills Neighborhood Council, Brin said, makes him familiar with issues of homelessness, crime, traffic, street condition and sanitation. A journalist who now produces publications for labor unions and health-plan trust funds, Brin earlier ran Jewish community newspapers, an experience he said gives him an appreciation for the obstacles facing small businesses.

Brin said the San Fernando Valley has been "neglected and despised" when it comes to funding for arts projects and mass-transit infrastructure. For example, he said, there's no museum in the Valley, even though its population matches Philadelphia's.

Regarding the sexual-harassment scandals that led to Dababneh's and Raul Bocanegra's resignations from the Assembly — and wider issues of the treatment of women in workplaces — Brin said: "I'm on the side of women. There needs to be meaningful protections against workplace harassment. We need due process to be followed, but we need situations where women have people who will listen to (them)."

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